

THE FOURTH STATE OF MATTER BY JO ANN BEARD

The Fourth State of Matter is a deeply personal essay by Jo Ann Beard, originally published in *The New Yorker* in 1996. It combines memoir, reflection, and reportage, weaving together threads of Beard's personal life and a tragic mass shooting at the University of Iowa in 1991. The essay is a poignant exploration of grief, change, and the fragility of human connections. Here's an overview:

Key Themes:

- 1. The Fluidity of Matter and Change:** The title refers to plasma, the fourth state of matter, and becomes a metaphor for the transformations in Beard's life. She juxtaposes this scientific concept with her own experiences of emotional, relational, and existential shifts.
- 2. Personal Loss and Grief:** Beard's essay reflects on the disintegration of her marriage and the impending death of her beloved dog, a symbol of unconditional love and companionship.
- 3. Violence and Loss in the Community:** The essay culminates in a retelling of a real-life tragedy—a shooting carried out by a disgruntled graduate student in the physics department where Beard worked. She conveys the randomness and senselessness of violence while honoring the victims' lives.
- 4. Human Connection:** Beard highlights the beauty and fragility of her relationships with colleagues, friends, and even her dog. These connections are tinged with both warmth and inevitability.

Writing Style:

Beard's prose is lyrical, blending precise detail with emotional depth. She employs vivid imagery and an understated tone to convey profound loss and reflection without overt sentimentality. Her ability to connect disparate elements—a dog's impending death, a violent tragedy, and the daily rhythms of life—creates a narrative that is both grounded and expansive.

Why It Resonates:

The essay's combination of personal and public grief makes it deeply relatable. It explores how people carry on in the face of devastating loss and how ordinary lives are interwoven with extraordinary events. Beard's use of humor, tenderness, and philosophical musings creates a richly textured piece.

Key Themes:

- **Grief and Loss:** The essay explores different kinds of losses—relationships, pets, friends, and innocence.
- **Isolation and Connection:** Beard juxtaposes her feelings of loneliness with the closeness she shares with her colleagues and her dog.
- **The Mundanity of Tragedy:** The story reflects how life continues in ordinary ways, even when tragedy is imminent or has already occurred.

Style:

Beard's writing is reflective and poetic, with vivid imagery and a quiet intensity. She masterfully blends personal narrative with journalistic detail, creating a piece that is both intimate and universally resonant.

"The Fourth State of Matter" is a profound exploration of resilience and the fragile, unpredictable nature of life.

EXERCISE:

Answer the following questions in two or three sentences:

1. What event is central to Jo Ann Beard's essay "The Fourth State of Matter"?
Ans: The central event in Jo Ann Beard's essay "The Fourth State of Matter" is the tragic shooting at the University of Iowa in 1991, which deeply influenced her reflections on grief, loss, and personal experiences.
2. What does the "fourth state of matter" refer to in the essay?
Ans: In Jo Ann Beard's essay "The Fourth State of Matter," the phrase refers to plasma, which is recognized as the fourth state of matter alongside solid, liquid, and gas. The essay explores scientific themes as well as personal narratives related to grief and loss. It also recounts a horrific workplace shooting at the University of Iowa that left many of her close colleagues dead.
3. How does the author describe her emotional state following the shooting?
Ans: Jo Ann Beard describes her emotional state following the shooting in "The Fourth State of Matter" as deeply affected and marked by a sense of disconnection and sorrow. The tragic events have a profound impact on her, leading her to reflect on loss, chaos, and the fragility of life. She conveys feelings of empathy for the victims while grappling with her own experiences and emotions in the aftermath of such violence.
4. What role does grief play in the author's reflections throughout the essay?
Ans: In "The Fourth State of Matter," grief plays a significant role as Jo Ann Beard reflects on the impact of a horrific workplace shooting at the University of Iowa. The

essay weaves together personal narratives and broader themes, using grief as a lens through which to explore the fragility of life and the inevitability of change. Beard's reflections illustrate how grief permeates (spreads) her experiences, influencing her feelings of loss and the stark (very much bare) reality of sudden violence, heightening the emotional weight of the narrative.

5. How does Jo Ann Beard use the metaphor of plasma in the essay?

Ans: Jo Ann Beard uses the metaphor of plasma in her essay "The Fourth State of Matter" to illustrate complex themes related to life, identity, and emotional states. She describes plasma as the fourth state of matter, akin to blood, drawing parallels between the scientific concept and her personal experiences, particularly in relation to grief, loss, and the permeability of human emotions. Permeability is the ability of a substance to allow gases or liquids to pass through it. In a more specific context, it can also refer to the property of a magnetizable substance that determines how it modifies the magnetic flux. This metaphor serves to connect the abstract nature of personal struggles with a tangible scientific reference, emphasizing the fluidity and interconnectedness of life's various elements.

6. How does the shooting at the university affect the narrator's sense of normalcy?

Ans: In Joe Ann Beard's "The Fourth State of Matter," the shooting at the university profoundly disrupts the narrator's sense of normalcy. Initially, the narrator attempts to maintain a semblance of routine amidst chaos, reflecting on everyday life and personal relationships. The violent event shatters this normalcy, forcing the narrator to confront the fragility of life and the unpredictable nature of existence. As the narrative unfolds, the contrast between the ordinary and the extraordinary highlights the impact of trauma, leading to a reevaluation of what "normal" truly means in the face of tragedy.

7. What is the significance of the narrator's dog in the essay?

Ans: The narrator's dog in Jo Ann Beard's essay "The Fourth State of Matter" serves as a poignant symbol of companionship and the emotional turmoil the narrator experiences. The dog's suffering and the narrator's care for it reflect deeper themes of vulnerability, loss, and the struggle with the uncontrollable aspects of life. The dog's presence introduces a sense of normalcy and routine amid the chaos surrounding the narrator, emphasizing the emotional weight of personal crises and the search for solace.

8. What does the essay reveal about the author's process of healing after the traumatic event?

Ans: In "The Fourth State of Matter," Jo Ann Beard's process of healing after the traumatic workplace shooting at the University of Iowa is revealed through her intertwining of personal reflection and broader existential themes. She navigates her grief

and trauma by exploring both her own experiences and the staggering impact of the event on the community. This blend allows her to make sense of the chaos, finding solace in the mundane aspects of life amidst the tragedy. She portrays healing as a nonlinear journey, marked by moments of clarity and confusion, as well as the intertwining of loss and memory.

Answer the following questions in a paragraph:

9. Describe how Jo Ann Beard juxtaposes everyday life with the trauma she experiences. How does this contrast highlight the emotional impact of the shooting?

Ans: Jo Ann Beard juxtaposes the mundanity of everyday life with the profound trauma she experiences by weaving together ordinary moments with the chaos and emotional upheaval resulting from the shooting. This contrast serves to amplify the emotional impact of the event, as the stark difference between routine activities and the harrowing reality of violence creates a dissonance that resonates deeply with the reader. Through her narrative, Beard captures how life continues in the face of trauma, highlighting the coexistence of horror and normalcy, which ultimately underscores the lingering effects of grief and loss on the psyche. In *The Fourth State of Matter*, she weaves tender moments of ordinary life—caring for her ailing dog, observing office dynamics, and reflecting on her personal struggles—into the narrative, creating a sense of normalcy and routine. This tranquility is abruptly shattered by the violence of the shooting, a contrast that heightens the reader's sense of shock and disorientation. By grounding the story in familiar, relatable experiences, Beard amplifies the horror of the tragedy, making its emotional weight deeply resonant. This interplay between the ordinary and the extraordinary forces the reader to confront the fragility of normalcy and the profound, lingering effects of trauma.

10. Explain how the author uses the concept of “plasma” to represent emotional and psychological turmoil. How does this metaphor help readers understand the depth of the narrator’s experience?

Ans: In Jo Ann Beard's essay *The Fourth State of Matter*, the concept of “plasma” serves as a central metaphor for the emotional and psychological turmoil experienced by the narrator. Plasma, a state of matter that is unstable, fluid, and constantly shifting, mirrors the narrator’s fragmented inner world as she copes with personal and professional upheavals. Her collapsing marriage, the imminent death of her beloved dog, and the looming tragedy at her workplace all contribute to a sense of chaos and disconnection. By likening her mental state to plasma—a form that defies stability and order—Beard vividly conveys the intensity of her distress and the fluid, unpredictable nature of grief and trauma. This metaphor not only deepens readers’ understanding of the narrator’s experience but also creates a visceral (relating to deep inward feelings rather than to the

intellect) connection, evoking the instability and fragility of life when faced with overwhelming loss and change.

11. Describe how Jo Ann Beard helps readers understand the concept of grief through her use of imagery and personal anecdotes in the essay?

Ans: In "*The Fourth State of Matter*," Jo Ann Beard conveys the profound weight of grief through vivid imagery and deeply personal anecdotes. Her descriptions transform ordinary scenes into poignant reflections of her emotional state, such as the swirling chaos of her neglected home, echoing her inner turmoil. The fluidity of her prose mirrors the instability of her world, as she intertwines moments of quiet loss with the sudden, devastating violence of the workplace shooting. Beard's personal anecdotes—her faltering relationship, the loss of her dog, and her connection to the victims—offer an intimate lens through which readers can feel the layered and often disjointed nature of grief. This combination of sensory detail and raw personal narrative helps readers grasp the all-encompassing, unpredictable, and transformative experience of mourning.

12. Describe the relationships the narrator shares with her co-workers. How do these relationships influence her reaction to the tragedy?

Ans: In "*The Fourth State of Matter*," Jo Ann Beard portrays her relationships with her co-workers as a blend of camaraderie (mutual trust and friendship among people who spend a lot of time together), routine connection, and subtle emotional distance. She shares a friendly and collegial bond with her colleagues, particularly Chris, who displays a caring, supportive demeanor, offering her companionship and a sense of normalcy amid her personal turmoil. These relationships, marked by shared humor and professional respect, create a fragile stability in her life. However, the sudden tragedy—the mass shooting—shatters this stability, leaving her reeling with grief and shock. The loss of her co-workers magnifies her sense of vulnerability and underscores the fragility of human connections, profoundly influencing her ability to process and cope with the event. These relationships, though understated, become central to the essay's emotional resonance as Beard navigates her sorrow and the dissonance of moving forward.

13. Compare the metaphor of plasma to the narrator's emotional state. How does this scientific concept mirror her psychological condition?

Ans: In Jo Ann Beard's "*The Fourth State of Matter*," the metaphor of plasma reflects her emotional state by illustrating the chaos and volatility in her life. Plasma, being a hot, ionized gas that is less stable than solids, liquids, or gases, symbolizes Beard's own emotional turmoil as she navigates through personal tragedies and the unpredictable nature of her surroundings. Just as plasma can penetrate and alter its environment, Beard's feelings of grief and confusion permeate her thoughts and experiences, often leading to moments of clarity amid the chaos. This metaphor captures the life-altering impact of loss and the struggle to find meaning in a disordered emotional landscape.

Essay questions:

14. Discuss how Jo Ann Beard's essay, "The Fourth State of Matter" explores the themes of grief, loss and emotional turmoil. How do these themes interact to shape the narrative and the author's journey of recovery?

Ans: Jo Ann Beard's essay, "The Fourth State of Matter," intricately weaves themes of grief, loss, and emotional turmoil into a narrative that reflects her personal journey through a period of profound change and tragedy. The essay juxtaposes the author's mundane life as a physics teacher with the chaos surrounding her, particularly the loss of her beloved dog and the tragic shooting at her workplace. This duality creates a powerful emotional landscape that explores how grief and loss permeate daily life and influence the process of recovery.

Beard's reflections on her dog's illness and eventual death serve as a poignant metaphor for her emotional state, illustrating how she grapples with the inevitability of loss. This personal grief is compounded by the external turmoil of the shooting incident, which shatters the safety and normalcy of her environment. The interplay between these two forms of loss highlights the complexity of emotional turmoil; Beard does not just mourn her dog but also the sense of security that is irrevocably altered by violence.

Throughout the essay, Beard employs a tone that oscillates between humor and sorrow, which allows her to navigate the heaviness of her experiences while still finding moments of levity. This balance is crucial in shaping the narrative, as it reflects the reality of living with grief—where moments of joy can coexist with profound sadness. As she recounts her experiences, Beard's journey of recovery becomes evident; she learns to embrace her grief rather than be consumed by it. The narrative illustrates that recovery is not a linear process but rather a complex interplay of acceptance and remembrance.

Ultimately, "The Fourth State of Matter" serves as a meditation on the nature of grief and the resilience of the human spirit. Beard's exploration of loss and emotional turmoil invites readers to reflect on their own experiences with grief and the ways in which it shapes their lives. Through her eloquent prose and vivid imagery, she transforms her personal story into a universal exploration of how we cope with the inevitable losses that life presents.

15. Analyze the role of memory and reflection in “The Fourth State of Matter”. How does the author’s introspection contribute to the overall meaning of the essay? Discuss how the writing style helps convey these reflective elements?

Ans: In Jo Ann Beard's essay “The Fourth State of Matter,” memory and reflection are central to the author's exploration of profound personal and existential themes. Through introspection, Beard examines her recollections of life, loss, and the interplay of varied emotional states, particularly as she navigates a personal crisis while recounting a tragic event at her workplace.

Beard employs a reflective narrative style that oscillates between poignant memory and immediate experience, allowing readers to engage in her thought process. This introspection enriches the essay's emotional depth, fostering a connection between the reader and the complexity of the author's feelings. The vivid memories of her late dog and reflections on the nature of her academic environment serve to ground the narrative in both personal experience and broader existential questions, highlighting themes of mortality, grief, and the search for meaning amid chaos.

The writing style is characterized by a lyrical yet concise approach, utilizing sensory details and metaphor. Beard's articulation of her memories transforms mundane elements of her life into powerful symbols of loss and contemplation. This blend of narrative and introspection not only deepens the thematic richness of the essay but also provides an immersive experience for the reader, inviting them to reflect on their own memories and the passage of time.

Beard's introspection shapes the essay's contemplative prism, encouraging readers to consider the fragility of life and the nature of memory itself. Through her reflective writing, the essay transcends the recounting of events, becoming a meditation on the interconnectedness of personal history and the collective experience of grief and resilience.